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CONTINUITY AND CHANGE IN REGIONAL PLANNING AND POLICY: SCHOLARSHIP IN THE STYLE OF WILLIAM ALONSO

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Commitment to regional policy analysis and counsel has long been a hallmark of leadership in regional science. In this article, the author traces the rise and disillusionment with development economics and its concern with backward regions, the emergence of deindustrialization as a regional challenge, opposing trends toward devolution and nation building, the rise of environmental concerns, and the resurgence of interest in metropolitan planning as successive high-water marks in regional policy making. Reflecting on the work of William Alonso, the author shows how a major theoretician in regional science bent his sights on the important policy issues of his times, evaluating options and forecasting new developments. While the objects of concern have changed, the author documents continuity in Alonso's zest for the knottier policy issues in the field of regional analysis and his contributions to each.

The paucity of regional policy and planning prescription has been an enduring criticism of regional science for the past twenty years. Few regional scientists are actively engaged in the process of exercising their insights on and in the real world of uneven regional development. In the early years of regional science, Walter Isard and others tried to apply their work on location and regional growth theory to concrete situations—Isard's work on steel mill location in the U.S. Northeast, for instance. William Alonso's scholarship is outstanding not only for the innovativeness of his thought but also for his continued commitment to and interest in regional policy and planning. His work in this regard shows a remarkable flexibility. He was willing to address the changing questions of his times. In the 1990s, for instance, he turned his attention to dramatic territorial reconfigurations in Europe, anticipating the shakeup in the hierarchy of cities and the strains on extant regional policy frameworks.

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In this brief essay, I review a number of upheavals that have changed the face of regional planning and policy since the early 1970s. John Friedmann (2001 [this issue]) implicitly suggests that regional planning is more or less dead and that few in the field would be interested in a third edited volume of *Readings*. I disagree. I hope to show the vitality of regional planning and policy in the contemporary period, albeit under new institutional forms and driven by new spatial and political challenges. Throughout this account, I weave the strong threads of Bill Alonso's thought and work.

THE DEBUT OF DEVELOPMENT ECONOMICS AND REGIONAL SCIENCE

In the golden days of the post–World War II period—the 1950s up through the Vietnam War—regions were differentially incorporated in the dramatic expansion of the world economy. Some regions and entire countries were left behind. Due to cold war competition, leading Western nations responded to communist formulas for development by adopting regional policies within their own borders and economic development strategies for developing countries. The countries most hotly contested—Korea, Taiwan, and Hong Kong—received the greatest attention; regional policies included land reform, urban decentralization, and growth pole strategies. But elsewhere, too—Africa and Latin America (where the Cuban experiment contested the capitalist development model)—regional and economic development policies were well-funded priorities of North American and European governments, as were efforts to ameliorate regional poverty and disinvestment in outlying regions at home.

The work of regional scientists provided important conceptual and empirical tools for such regional planning efforts. The volumes that William Alonso and John Friedmann edited in the 1960s and 1970s (Friedmann and Alonso 1964, 1975) showcased some of the best of this work. Several features mark these volumes and convey the preoccupations of the times: an explicit concern for equity as well as efficiency, a continued appreciation for the significance of natural resources as a chief differentiator among regions, an insistence on the significance of the spatial dimension of economic development policies, an infatuation with spatial geometry, and a fair number of prescriptions for regional policy and planning but few evaluations of their effectiveness.

DISILLUSIONMENT WITH POSTWAR REGIONAL AND ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT POLICY

Much of this context changed in the last quarter of the twentieth century. First, the Vietnam War, the palpable underperformance of communist economies, and disappointing performance in the developing world brought considerable disillusionment with prevailing economic development and regional policies. From the 1970s on, a flurry of critiques were written of everything from growth poles (e.g., Peattie

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1987, on Ciudad Guyana) to failed regional strategies for industrializing backward regions (e.g., Goldsmith and Wilson 1991, on northeast Brazil). Bill Alonso elegantly characterizes such policies and their disappointing results in his article, "From Alfred Weber to Max: The Shifting Style of Regional Policy" (1990, 31). Efforts to stem rural migration to the largest cities in the developing world seemed not to be working, and income inequality between the rich and poor countries of the world was growing (Giminez et al. 1977). In addition, industrial policy priorities often overrode weaker regional policy efforts (Markusen 1996b, 1996c; Alonso 1996).

Regional Planning in Deindustrializing Regions

In the early 1970s, quickening in the pace of world economic integration, itself the product of aggressive policy leadership on the part of the United States and its European allies, began to create new kinds of stresses at home. Suddenly, the troubled regions in policy makers' focus were no longer the persistent poverty of the Appalachians and the Mezzogiornos but mature and relatively high-income industrial regions such as Manchester, Pittsburgh, and Galicia. Their comparative advantages in textiles, steel, and ships were eroded by new export-oriented manufacturing capabilities in the newly industrialized countries. Entire metropolitan areas, especially their inner cities, became the new regions in distress. Old planning formulas, which used poverty, per capital income, inferior education, and accessibility measures to identify regions worthy of intervention, did not fit this new reality.

In response, a whole new literature emerged in political economy and geography stressing the extent to which the fortunes of a single region depended on forces, including national policies, residing beyond their borders (Massey and Meegan 1978; Bluestone and Harrison 1982). Measures such as unemployment, displacement, plant closings, and underused infrastructure were proposed as the basis for new forms of regional development assistance in the United States and Britain. The Thatcher and Nixon/Ford governments in this period were relatively hostile to blue-collar communities because residents of the latter voted principally for opposition parties.

As a result, many state and local governments were forced to begin their own innovative economic development programs. Some sought to prevent or curtail plant closings; others encouraged entrepreneurship in new sectors (Luria and Russell 1981). Outstanding among these in the United States were Massachusetts's Industrial Services Program, Michigan's Manufacturing Extension Service and Auto and Steel Division of the Department of Commerce, and Mayor Harold Washington's Task Force on Steel and Southeast Chicago (Markusen 1985). These initiatives led national policy, which subsequently followed with plant closing laws, beefed-up displaced workers programs, and manufacturing extension services.

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DEVOLUTION AS REGIONAL POLICY

In the 1970s, restive regional elites in the United States (the American South and West), Canada (Montreal), and Europe (especially Wales, Scotland, Catalan, and the Basque country) organized to force the devolution of power, finances, and regulation from central governments toward state and provincial governments. Often, strong regional identity based on language, religion, history, and industrial specializations fed these movements, and most also were connected with economic aspirations. In some cases, it was the richer rather than the poorer regions demanding greater autonomy. Over the next twenty years, significant devolution in governance structures took place in the European areas, often in connection with regime changes in the central government. In some cases—Catalonia, for instance—the result has been the intellectual, cultural, and economic resurgence of a region.

But devolution has shown another face as well. Beginning with the Nixon administration's new federalism, fiscal stress and conservative ideologies encouraged many national governments to abandon explicit regional policies and replace them with devolutionist strategies. Although these were clothed in rhetoric about the superiority of local control and the salutary effects of competition between regions, in practice, devolution has meant that the nation-state no longer tries to address regional imbalances and expects subnational governments to take up the burden of economic development (Markusen 1996a; Porter 1996). Alonso (1990, 30) characterizes this succinctly: "But in all, the shift in emphasis toward extolling and relying on local initiatives and entrepreneurship, whether public, private or mixed, serves the purpose of abating the national need to deal directly with regional economic issues."

In response, subnational governments have done so, creating an entirely new field of local economic development practice. Despite fewer resources and less authority than the nation-state, remarkable innovations have emerged from this necessity. These include industrial policies as mentioned above, as well as novel ways of financing infrastructure and land redevelopment, greater interest in training and workforce development, entrepreneurial initiatives, and integrated community development and planning efforts. Such spatial planning processes, which span multistate regions and neighborhoods, are often more participatory than either the 1930s territorial or 1950s functionalist regional planning approaches. They are subject to continual scrutiny by politicians, newspapers, citizens, and special interests. Although this process is more democratic, outcomes may be deformed by power imbalances among protagonists.

NEW NATION BUILDING

This evolution in local capacity is paralleled by the creation of many new nations following the breakup of the Soviet Union. These new nations are struggling with formidable economic development challenges at the same time that they are

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fashioning new democratic governance structures. Here, too, the need for economic development counsel and spatial strategies is great (Alonso 1993).

In a countertendency, some nations have decided that they are too small to compete against large nations such as the United States and have decided to build supranational regions. The European Union is the outstanding example of this. How this integration would affect the European system of cities and regional disparities was one of Bill Alonso's last intellectual projects (Alonso 1989a, 1989b, 1991, 1992). The European Union has recommitted itself to regional policy in the past few years, building a new spatial strategy and doubling the amount of moneys available to disadvantaged regions (Commission of the European Communities 1999). In the case of Germany, the reabsorption of the former East Germany has been *the* major project of the 1990s, a project that has demanded considerable attention to regional policy and planning. At the same time, some European regional governments have become increasingly entrepreneurial as well. In federal Germany, for instance, the states have built large and active economic development agencies. In the "Third Italy," city governments have played a coordinating role in the upgrading of mature manufacturing industries.

Environmental Planning as Regional Planning

Husbanding of the natural environment has become a central feature of modern regional development practice. Reversing the regional science emphasis on resource development as synonymous with extraction and returning to earlier territorial development sensibilities (Friedmann and Weaver 1979), the environmental movement has forced a new emphasis on environmental protection and sustainability in regional development planning and policy. In rural areas, the environmental dimension of regional planning focuses on sustainable agriculture, forestry and recreation, and wilderness preservation. In urban areas, environmentally driven regional planning means containing sprawl, protecting wetlands, improving air quality, and creating environmental amenities that will attract and retain skilled workers and entrepreneurs.

Metropolitan Planning

Because of fragmented local government structures, metropolitan areas in many parts of the world face mounting problems of coping with environmental, infrastructure, and housing imbalances that spill over from one jurisdiction to the next. Despite an intellectual tradition celebrating such fragmentation as good for citizen consumers (Tiebout 1956) and three decades of relative stasis in metropolitan governance, new interest in metropolitan-wide land use, transportation, infrastructure, and even economic development planning emerged in the 1990s, led by sophisticated and successful political initiatives in regions such as Portland and Minneapolis (Orfield 1997; Porter 1995). These have captured the interest of other regions

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and of national governments. In the United States, legislation passed in the 1990s requires that every metropolitan area wishing to receive moneys from the large new transportation initiative, ISTEA, must designate a Metropolitan Planning Organization. This has proved to be a major incentive for deadlocked regions to create new metropolitan planning institutions. Paralleling these pioneering efforts, economists and geographers have begun to write about city-states and metropolitan regions as the new building blocks of the world economy, stressing common stakes of all residents in the region's future (Barnes and Ledebur 1998; Storper 1997; Scott 1998; Amin and Thrift 1994).

Progress in Evaluating Regional Planning and Policy

Finally, many of these spatial and economic development strategies have been subjected to considerable evaluative scrutiny, thanks to the emergence of a local economic development specialization within planning; the creation of new journals, such as *Economic Development Quarterly*, *International Journal of Urban and Regional Research*, and *International Regional Science Review*; and the changing face of journals such as *Growth and Change*, *Regional Studies*, and *Economic Geography*. In place of a toolkit restricted to spatial analysis and regional methods, regional planners are now taught a broader range of causal theories of regional development, and they are exposed to a rich and growing evaluative literature on what works. Of course, our ability to test whether a particular intervention works is subject to the same knotty problems as any social or economic experiment—how do we control for all other changes that affect the outcome?

Regional planners and policy makers have increasingly used multivariate analysis for this purpose, and data sources are arguably much better and more numerous now than in previous decades. Andrew Isserman and his colleagues have pioneered the use of quasi-experimental methods to evaluate regional development programs, with important findings (Isserman and Beaumont 1989; Isserman and Rephann 1995). Qualitative methods such as interviewing and ethnography are increasingly used for testing theories about corporate strategy, networking, and industrial district character (Schoenberger 1991; Healey and Rawlinson 1993; Markusen 1994; Saxenian 1994). We know much more now about the extent to which past and current economic development and regional planning approaches deliver.

Conclusion

William Alonso was an intellectual leader in regional planning. He began as a student of Walter Isard's, deeply engaged in the analytics of regional science. In his first work (Alonso 1964), he fashioned the brilliant and durable theory of metropolitan land use, a remarkable application of the agricultural land use model of von Thunen. But he was also, to use Mike Teitz's wonderful phrase, "bit by the policy bug." Throughout his career, he wrote about and advised on some of the most

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important regional policy issues of the times, from regional policy to migration policy. He understood the profound postwar challenge to regional science from neoclassical economics, with its celebration of market forces, and wrote about it in his piece "From Alfred Weber to Max Weber" (Alonso 1990). He commented on new developments in metropolitan growth patterns in the 1970s and mused about the effect of deindustrialization on regional policy in the 1980s. Toward the end of his life, he was deeply engaged in debates about European regional restructuring in the 1990s, from the future of regional policy in the newly integrated European Union (Alonso 1989b) to the shakeup in the European system of cities (Alonso 1991, 1992) to the post-Soviet Eastern European experiments (Alonso 1993).

What of the hallmarks of the Friedmann and Alonso volumes? Would a new collection be different in focus? Yes. Spatial geometry has given way to institutionalist and political economy approaches. Regional planning and policy have devolved onto lower units of government, where they are more accessible to the average citizen, more conflictual, and less well funded but undoubtedly more innovative. Gone is the remote expert planner who from an office in the capital city decides which cities will be anointed as growth poles and which regions will reap extraordinary infrastructure expenditures. Whole societies, new and old, are building regional institutions, while planners are engaged in innovative experiments in local economic development.

But there is continuity as well. The concern for equity as well as efficiency is at the heart of the "metropolitics" movement (Orfield 1997). Natural environments continue to be a focus, albeit in a novel form. Above all, the spatial and regional dimensions of economic development continue to attract policy makers and citizens' attention. We owe Bill Alonso a big debt for his thought, his flexibility, his straightforward and powerful writing style, and his unflinching interest in the thorny real world of regional development and politics.

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